Archives and Afterlives: Interpreting Cultural Artifacts in the Digital Age

76-101 / FALL 2026

Instructor: Laura DeLuca (she/they)
ldeluca@andrew.cmu.edu
Classroom: WEH 5316
Office hours: By appointment via Zoom
Zoom: https://cmu.zoom.us/j/8564286385



Course Description

Why do some stories get remembered while others disappear? Who decides what counts as history, and how does media shape the way we understand the past? By analyzing how historical narratives are shaped through processes of preservation, mediation, and interpretation, students will consider how authority, evidence, and storytelling operate across different genres. Through these questions, we will uncover how the archive continues to shape our understanding of history, knowledge, and cultural memory.

Students will analyze examples of representation in both historical and contemporary media, such as how the British Library website presents and organizes its collections in ways that frame Britain's historical past as coherent and largely unproblematic for public audiences, how librarians at institutions like CMU's Special Collections determine which documents are preserved and made accessible, and how collaborative platforms like Wikipedia structure and revise information about public figures. For instance, pages on Queen Elizabeth II are continually updated as editors respond to shifting public narratives about women in power, shaping how female rule is represented, interpreted, and understood across time. These cases demonstrate that representation is never neutral: the ways materials are preserved, organized, and circulated shape what counts as historical knowledge and whose perspectives are included or left out. Students will ask questions such as: Why are certain voices missing from the historical record? How do movies, websites, or online databases shape public understanding of the past? What happens when historical materials are edited, digitized, or circulated online? By studying how narratives are created and repeated across different forms of media, students will develop critical reading and writing skills that help them better understand the relationship between storytelling, power, and cultural memory.

Throughout the course, students will develop their skills in genre-based analysis and collaborative discussion, deepening their understanding of how cultural biases influence the politics of representation. As the course progresses, students will identify a unique research gap within these discussions and compose a formal research proposal that articulates the significance of the gap that their research aims to fill. This proposal will serve as the foundation for a final academic paper, where students will investigate a topic related to archives, media, or cultural representation and write a research paper that explores how stories about the past continue to shape the present.

All required readings are available on Canvas.

Learning Objectives

At Carnegie Mellon, we hope our students will be able to understand their environments, assess rhetorical needs, and use their knowledge and resources to craft documents that connect with readers. After taking 76-101, you should be able to write interpretive essays that are compelling, careful, clear, and considerate of your readers. You should be able to:

- Genre and Language Knowledge: to read, observe and adapt models for writing your own text that connects with readers.
- Academic Inquiry and Research Knowledge: to construct a relevant academic contribution that comes from inquiry, careful reading, and engagement with multiple existing perspectives.
- Argument Knowledge: to recognize, invent and produce reasonable arguments that convince readers in an academic discourse community.
- Knowledge and Collaboration: to use oral modes of communication to communicate your argument

Assignments

The course employs academic and public arguments to develop students' critical reading and writing practices. The major writing assignments are organized in a cumulative sequence of essays:

1. **Comparative Genre Analysis (CGA)**, in which students compare two articles, one for experts and one for nonexperts, to explain how different rhetorical purposes and audiences interact with the argument and structure of a text—and to what extent those interactions matter.
2. **Research Proposal (Prop)**, in which students propose a research question and a research plan to resolve that question. The proposal includes a short synthesis of relevant research material that ties together a number of distinct sources into one coherent description of a research gap.
3. **Contribution (Contrib)**, in which students contribute to the academic conversation by reporting the results of their proposed project by writing either a thesis-driven or IMRAD structured research article.

Grading Overview

Homework 30%
Includes low-stakes assignments related to essay prewriting, including some in-class assignments. Extra Credit for Homework points will be occasionally available. Graded based on completion and quality of work.

Comparative Genre Analysis 10%
800-1,000 words. In the Comparative Genre Analysis Essay, you will make an argument about what you have discovered by analyzing and comparing two different texts, one written for an expert audience and the other for a non-expert audience. Your job is to communicate to your readers how different rhetorical purposes and audiences interact with the argument and structure of a text—and to what extent those

interactions matter. Includes pre-writing, two drafts, peer review, and a reflection. Graded based on a rubric.

Proposal 20%
1,000-1,500 words. This assignment is a Proposal for the research you will undertake in your Contribution Paper. The Proposal is aimed at informing stakeholders of the exigence, overview, objectives, academic context, and plan of work for your Contribution research. Includes pre-writing, one draft, peer review, and a reflection. Graded based on a rubric.

Contribution Paper 30%
1,500-2,500 words. This paper is an argument-driven essay that responds to the research questions outlined in your Proposal. Your contribution argument may extend or strengthen an existing perspective, add a new perspective, apply a perspective or test an approach in a new context, reconcile apparently opposing views, but must make use of at least 8 sources. The paper can be organized as a thesis-driven essay or an IMRaD paper. Includes pre-writing, one draft, peer review, and a presentation to the class. Graded based on a rubric.

Participation and Attendance 10% Ongoing
Includes attendance to class meetings, 1:1 conferences, general engagement and active participation in class meetings (see below for grading details).

The CMU Student Senate voted to do away with pluses and minuses in final grades. I round up from the point-five (i.e., an 89.5 and above is an A). Please understand that I have to be consistent to be fair.

Grading Standards: A (90-100) B (80-89) C (70-79) D (60-69) R (below 60)

Course Overview and Policies

As you may or may not know from the university's first-year writing course descriptions document, you have enrolled in a half-semester course called a "mini." This mini is worth 4.5 units, which means that it is half of a 9-unit course. The number of hours you should expect to work in this course is 9 hours per week—3 of those hours will be used for class time.

This course aims toward helping you build skills for noticing and writing about features of artistic and literary texts. Unlike the two other minis offered by first-year writing, this course focuses upon the academic writing situation usually associated with humanities and the arts. We focus on the academic communication genre referred to as the interpretive analytical essay form, usually known as a thesis-driven essay that emerges from sources. The other two mini courses focus on different communication genres and use different organizational patterns, including problem/solution/feasibility in public problems and IMRD in writing about data.

Class Participation and Note-taking
You must do the assigned homework and come prepared to participate in class. You are expected to:
- Contribute to general class discussions,

- Contribute to small group discussions,
- Seek feedback from other class members on work in progress, and
- Provide thoughtful feedback to other class members on their work.

Being prepared for this class includes:
- Paying close attention to the assignments for each class,
- Doing the homework, and
- Bringing relevant materials with you to class.

Deadlines

All written assignments must be submitted before the deadline. Please bear in mind the following policies regarding lateness:

- **Rough Drafts:** Rough drafts for the major assignments will not be accepted late. Peer review is a time-sensitive process, and by submitting a draft late you interfere with your classmates' progress.
- **Graded Drafts: For every day that a final draft is late, you will lose a full letter grade for that paper.** However, final drafts of the contribution paper (the third assignment) **will not be accepted late.** Extensions may be granted under extraordinary circumstances at my discretion, but only if you contact me prior to the final deadline.
- **Homework assignments:** We will often draw on or discuss homework assignments in class; for this reason, I expect homework to be submitted on time. you are still responsible for completing and submitting the day's homework if you do not attend class.

**Failing to attach a file to Canvas correctly (so that I can't access or view it) can result in your losing credit for an assignment. It's your responsibility to make sure that your assignments have been submitted successfully. If you are concerned about a Canvas submission, you can always email it to me as a "safety net."

General Guidelines on Submitting Assignments

- Please note that to receive a passing grade, you must hand in the major papers.
- Assignments must be submitted in electronic form, as word .doc or .docx files, pdfs, or as canvas posts. check assignment guidelines for specifics.
- Carefully edit and proofread all texts to control problems in grammar, spelling, and punctuation.
- Any time you cite an essay, film, or book in an assignment, include a works cited section of your essay that provides complete and accurate bibliographic information.

Attendance and Lateness

Since this is a small discussion class, attendance is mandatory. The reason this class has an attendance policy is so that we practice what we preach—that academic texts are built in collaboration with other readers and writers and not in isolation, and that academic authors are responsible to a community of

knowledge makers. In this class and in our professional lives, we make knowledge that is valuable to a community through talk, interaction, and connection.

Arrive on time. You won't get an A in this class if you can't get here on time. Lateness not only disrupts the class but also shows a good deal of disrespect for your peers and for your instructor. For every three days you are late to class, you will be marked for one absence. If you are more than 15 minutes late to class, you will be marked absent for that day. Sleeping in class can result in being marked absent.

You are allotted two absences in this class without penalty—once you miss that third class, your grade in the class will begin to drop. Treat this attendance policy like a "personal" or "sick day" policy you might find in a workplace. In other words, these absences usually occur because of minor illnesses or schedule conflicts (e.g., a delayed Monday morning flight after a weekend holiday).

Plan ahead if you think you might miss class for religious holidays or for other scheduled events. You need to plan your semester carefully so that you do not use all of your personal/sick days at once.

In the case of university-sanctioned activities (e.g., athletics or a course-specific trip that takes you out of town), you ***must provide documentation*** for these absences so that they do not count against your final grade.

If you have extenuating circumstances that could affect your attendance throughout the semester (such as illness, athletics, or a family emergency), it is your responsibility to notify me about your situation and to get some sort of authoritative documentation to excuse your absences. This kind of documentation should originate from the Dean's office, typically, because in these circumstances a student's academic advising team is coordinating communication with all of your faculty. Notes from family doctors are insufficient for documenting extenuating circumstances.

If you miss a class meeting, you are responsible to contact your peers for materials and information you've missed. Missing a class is no excuse for not completing the homework. Likewise, I expect you to have read the assigned readings and to be ready to discuss them, even if you were absent the class before. All of our reading is immediately relevant to the course's assignments, so consider your readings just as important as any written homework you have. I can call on people in class discussion, and it's embarrassing (for you and for me) to have to announce to the class that you haven't done the reading.

Using Sources Properly and Academic Integrity

At Carnegie Mellon, we believe in the excellence of our students and in the integrity of our academic programs. We also believe that your good ideas become better when you test them against the ideas of others. At the same time, we believe that acknowledging this kind of collaboration with others is an important aspect of membership in an academic community. In this course, the following kinds of collaboration and assistance are permitted: a) in-class collaboration such as group work, pair work, class discussion, and peer review; b) discussing your ideas regarding the three major assignments with other students; c) graded peer reviews; d) assistance provided by the student academic success center (https://www.cmu.edu/student-success/).

Any collaboration or assistance of these types should be acknowledged in writing; we will discuss how to incorporate such acknowledgments in your writing in this course. Also within this course, it is imperative that you discuss with me when it is appropriate to use your writing from a completed assignment (from either this class or from another one) within a new writing task. University policy is clear that students cannot use text from a graded assignment from one course for another assignment in another course without discussing your decision making with your instructors.

Anyone who uses non-documented material from another source, including work by other students as well as online sources (including unauthorized assistance from AI tools like Chat GPT), could receive a failing grade for the entire course and could be referred to the dean's office for further disciplinary action.

Incomplete Grades

University policy states the following about incomplete grades:
"Carnegie Mellon students are expected to complete a course during the academic semester in which the course was taken. However, if the instructor agrees, a grade of 'I' (incomplete) may be given when a student, for reasons beyond his or her control, has been unable to complete the work of a course, but the work completed to date is of passing quality and the grade of incomplete provides no undue advantage to that student over other students.

In awarding an 'I' grade, an instructor must specify the requirements for completing the work and designate a default letter grade where no further work is submitted. Students must complete the required course work no later than the end of the following academic semester, or sooner if required by prior agreement. the instructor must record the permanent grade by the last day of the examination period of that following semester, or enrollment services will administratively assign the default grade." (via https://www.cmu.edu/policies/student-and-student-life/grading.html)

A student requesting a grade of "I" in a department of English course must meet the above conditions, including having completed a sufficient amount of course work (at least 50%, ideally 70%). The student should be completing the same work that everyone else in the course will complete. There must be a written contract, available from the instructor, that shows agreement about what work needs to be completed, the deadline by which the work should be submitted, and what the default grade will be should the work not be submitted by the deadline. Cases in which a graduating student requests an "i" grade must be discussed by the instructor and the department head.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you have a disability and have an accommodations letter from the Disability Resources office, I encourage you to discuss your accommodations and needs with me as early in the semester as possible. I will work with you to ensure that accommodations are provided as appropriate. If you suspect that you may have a disability and would benefit from accommodations but are not yet registered with the Office of Disability Resources, I encourage you to contact them at access@andrew.cmu.edu.

Statement on Diversity

The topics that we're covering in this class are often difficult, not just intellectually but emotionally. While I expect there to be rigorous discussion and even disagreement in the course of our class discussions, I ask that you engage in discussion with care and empathy for the other members in the classroom. Aim to disagree without becoming disagreeable. In this class we will not shy away from the uncomfortable. Critically examining and assessing our most basic assumptions and values is not just one of the tasks of philosophy but is an activity vital to living an authentic life. I urge you to have the courage to the uncomfortable in this class. In exchange for your courage, I will work to ensure a classroom environment that supports your taking these intellectual and emotional risks.

Furthermore, all people have the right to be addressed and referred to in accordance with their personal identity. In this class, we will have the chance to indicate the name that we prefer to be called and, if we choose, to identify pronouns with which we would like to be addressed. I will do my best to address and refer to all students accordingly and support classmates in doing so as well.

Inclusive, Reader-Oriented Language Choices

In this class, we take a reader-oriented view of language and standards, and I encourage you to make decisions about your written language choices according to how your reader may respond. This view means that we use language to connect with a community of readers and that we do not use language that might alienate anybody in that community. In other words, we use language to create particular effects for our readers. If we want to communicate professionalism, we use a style guide for our academic writing. If we want to communicate that we are writing with precision, we use conventions such as appropriate verb tenses. To that end, I encourage you to use language that does not exclude or alienate readers. For example, consider the latest conventions for referring to race and class that do not mark difference or communicate to our readers that they are somehow "other." Another example for writing inclusively is to use non-binary gendered pronouns. The emerging convention for using gendered pronouns is that we should consider writing in a style that includes both the feminine and masculine, using a gender-neutral plural form (*they*) in place of binary pronouns like he/she. The National Council of Teachers in English (NCTE) gives us some examples on their website http://www.ncte.org/positions/statements/genderfairuseoflang. Whenever possible, we aim to use our language to build connections with our audience. Using inclusive language can help us make that connection. (Note: Language conventions are tricky and situated. In other words, reason about them. Don't apply language formulas.)

Student Academic Success & Communication Support

During the semester (and across your undergraduate years), you may find that you would like to pursue extra support for your writing. You can find support for your academic work and for your writing and communication skills in the following ways:

- Make a 1:1 virtual appointment with a writing tutor through the Communication Support Team at Student Academic Success
- Attend writing skills workshops offered by Communication Support
- Seek language support or find a Study Partner offered through Student Academic Success

You can find these and other services by going to the Student Academic Success website: https://www.cmu.edu/student-success/

Guidelines for Self-Care: First Things First

This semester should be challenging, engaging, and fruitful. Make choices so that you can act with resilience as you face the unfolding demands and expectations of college life. Being resilient means that you can bounce back from setbacks and disappointments and that you can take on somewhat intimidating tasks. **Resilient people make sure that they get sleep, eat a variety of foods, stay connected with friends, and get some physical exercise.**

However, don't be embarrassed if you're having trouble keeping "first things first." Ask for help. All of us benefit from support during times of struggle. You are not alone. There are many helpful resources available on campus, and an important part of the college experience is learning how to ask for help. Remember the message you heard during orientation week: *It is a sign of strength to ask for help.*

If you or anyone you know experiences any academic stress, difficult life events, or feelings like anxiety or depression, I strongly encourage you to seek support. Counseling and Psychological Services (CaPS) is here to help: call 412-268-2922 and visit their website at http://www.cmu.edu/counseling/. Consider reaching out to a friend, faculty or family member you trust for help getting connected to the support that can help. You can feel free to talk to me at any time, and I'll do my best to get you the support you need.

Grading Criteria for all Minor Writing Assignments (unless otherwise specified)

Well Done Work Full points (5/5 or 10/10)	Fair Work 8/9 or 4 points	Needs a lot of Work 7 or below/3 or below
The assignment criteria have been met thoughtfully and with insight. The analysis is planned and articulated with convincing detail**;** questions are thoroughly answered.	The assignment criteria have been met with some evidence of effort and thought in this assignment. However, responses may be cursory, lacking necessary connections, or lack key aspects of the assignment.	The assignment criteria may have been met, but these assignments do not move beyond broad generalizations. The work is hard to read, incomplete, or presented poorly.

Revise and Resubmit Policy

Eligibility

You are only eligible to revise and resubmit a specified assignment for the semester in which you are currently enrolled, i.e., you cannot revise and resubmit work for a previous semester.

Additionally, eligible students will have submitted assignment drafts – and scaffolding work leading up to it – by the agreed upon due dates.

Requirements of Resubmission

To initiate the revise & resubmit process, students should speak with their instructor. For this class, you must meet with the instructor outside of class to set up a "Plan for Success" that will detail the work that must be completed and dates that this work must be completed by. You also must fill out this Revise and Resubmit Form.

Once you complete the "Revise & Resubmit Document" you will be asked to:

1. Submit Original Assignment w. Instructor Comments
2. Submit Revised Assignment that highlights changes

3. Submit a reflection statement of 250-300 words explaining the changes and rationale behind them.

Regrading Policy

You can earn up to full credit for the assignment *depending on the quality and completeness of the revision* and *your accounting of your revision choices in your reflection*. Instructors are not obligated to provide additional comments on the re-graded assignment.

Generative AI Policy

Please see this Policy of AI use statement for full explanation. Key points:

- Certain assignments in this course may permit or even encourage the use of generative artificial intelligence (GAI) tools such as Copilot. Any such use must be appropriately acknowledged and cited. It is each student's responsibility to assess the validity and applicability of any GAI output that is submitted; you bear the final responsibility.

- **The default is that AI use for anything other than grammar or spell check is disallowed** unless otherwise stated or fully discussed with and approved by the instructor in advance. Violations of this policy will be considered academic misconduct. We draw your attention to the fact that different classes could implement different AI policies, and it is the student's responsibility to conform to expectations for each course.

During some class sessions, we may leverage generative AI tools to support your learning, provide you with an opportunity to explore how they can be used, and/or better understand their benefits and limitations. Learning how to use AI is an emerging skill, and we will work through the implications of these evolving systems together, during class sessions. However, use of generative AI will be limited to exercises during class sessions. I will always indicate when and where use of AI tools during class sessions is appropriate (and not). Examples of use during ungraded classroom exercises might include:

- brainstorming new ideas,
- developing example outlines or approaches to your work, and/or
- generating different ways to talk about a problem.

In contrast, you may not use AI tools to generate work for an assignment to be submitted for a grade, as this cannot be considered a substitute for developing the fundamental skills and expertise represented by the learning objectives of this course. Please note that generative AI tools rely on predictive models to generate content that may appear correct, but has been shown to sometimes be incomplete, inaccurate, taken without attribution from other sources, and/or biased. Consequently, an AI tool should not be considered a substitute for traditional approaches to research and you should complete all graded assignments without any assistance from AI tolls. You are ultimately responsible for the content of the information you submit and may not attempt to pass off any work generated by an AI program as your own.

Course Calendar

Fall 2026 · Archives and Afterlives

Week and date	Class focus	Readings and assignments
Week 1 **Tu. Aug. 25**	Introduction to 76-101	—
Week 1 **Th. Aug. 27**	Making a Claim; introduction to CREVEXPL; reading an academic article; rhetorical audiences	Geoffrey C. Bowker and Susan Leigh Star, “Some Tricks of the Trade in Analyzing Classification” Claire Voon, “Artists Covertly Scan Bust of Nefertiti and Release the Data for Free Online”
Week 2 **Tu. Sept. 1**	No class!	Be prepared to discuss Bowker and Star, and Voon readings!
Week 2 **Th. Sept. 3**	Making claims and using evidence Discuss Bowker and Star, Voon readings Begin CREVEXPL assignment	Melissa K. Chalmers and Paul N. Edwards, “Producing ‘One Vast Index’: Google Book Search as an Algorithmic System” Scott Rosenberg, “How Google Book Search Got Lost”
Week 3 **Tu. Sept. 8**	Motivating claims + activity; introduce Comparative Genre Analysis (CGA); CREVEXPL 2 activity Discuss Chalmers and Edwards, Rosenberg readings Comparative genre analysis: analyzing arguments, audiences, and rhetorical choices in expert vs. non-expert texts	Complete CREVEXPL assignment on Canvas by 9/10 at 9am! to Canvas by 9/11 at midnight (worth
Week 3 **Th. Sept. 10**	Continue comparative readings; developing a comparative claim;	to Canvas by 9/11 at midnight (worth Lara Putnam, “The Transnational and the Text-Searchable: Digitized Sources and the Shadows They Cast” Jill Lepore,“The Cobweb: Can the Internet Be Archived?”
Week 4 **Tu. Sept. 15**	Intro to AWS + CLS resources Discuss Putnam and Lepore readings	Complete CGA task analysis by Thursday at 9am!

Course Calendar

Fall 2026 · Archives and Afterlives

Week and date	Class focus	Readings and assignments
Week 4 **Th. Sept. 17**	CGA in-class writing day	Sign up for a mandatory one-on-one Conference during Week 6! This conference is how you will get feedback on your CGA Draft. Major assignment: CGA Rough Draft Due Sunday, September 20 by midnight on Canvas
Week 5 **Tu. Sept. 22**	CGA peer review	—
Week 5 **Th. Sept. 24**	CGA in-class writing/revisions CGA Rough Draft Due Sunday, September 27 by midnight on Canvas	—
Week 6 **Tu. Sept. 29**	No class – INDIVIDUAL CONFERENCES	—
Week 6 **Th. Oct. 1**	No class – INDIVIDUAL CONFERENCES	Major assignment: CGA Final Draft Due Sunday, October 4 by midnight on Canvas
Week 7 **Tu. Oct. 6**	Documentary/media analysis: representation, historical narrative, and cultural memory	Proposal Task Analysis submit on Canvas by Thursday at 9am!
Week 7 **Th. Oct. 8**	Introduce Research Proposal + Inquiry Plan; task analysis; developing research questions	Read Kolln, “Cohesion” (on Canvas) Read Hayot, “The Uneven U” (on Canvas)
Week 8 **Tu. Oct. 20**	Argumentative “moves” of proposals; thesis-driven essays; reader-centered prose and BLUF	*They Say/I Say* (TSIS), Chapter 1 Submit Inquiry Plan by Thursday at 9am!
Week 8 **Th. Oct. 22**	Establishing exigence; identifying a research gap; framing a potential contribution	*They Say/I Say* (TSIS), Chapter 2
Week 9 **Tu. Oct. 27**	Finding, evaluating, and annotating sources	*They Say/I Say* (TSIS), Chapter 3

Course Calendar

Fall 2026 · Archives and Afterlives

Week and date	Class focus	Readings and assignments
Week 9 **Th. Oct. 29**	Synthesizing perspectives and writing a literature review	Work on proposals! Major assignment: Proposal Rough Draft Due November 1 by midnight on Canvas
Week 10 **Tu. Nov. 3**	No Class – Democracy day	—
Week 10 **Th. Nov. 5**	Proposal in-class writing workshop	—
Week 11 **Tu. Nov. 10**	Proposal peer review	*They Say/I Say* (TSIS), Chapter 4
Week 11 **Th. Nov. 12**	Proposal revision workshop; introduce Contribution Paper and Presentation; moving from research gap to contribution	*They Say/I Say* (TSIS), Chapter 5 Major assignment: Proposal Final Draft Due Sunday, November 15 by midnight on Canvas
Week 12 **Tu. Nov. 17**	Building and supporting a contribution; case studies; introduction to the Known-New Contract	Submit Contribution Paper Task Analysis by Thursday at 9am!
Week 12 **Th. Nov. 19**	Known-New Contract continued; organization and reader expectations	Major assignment: Contribution Paper Rough Draft Due Sunday, November 22 by midnight on Canvas
Week 13 **Tu. Nov. 24**	No class – INDIVIDUAL CONFERENCES	—
Week 13 **Th. Nov. 26**	No class – Thanksgiving Break!	—
Week 14 **Tu. Dec. 1**	Student Presentations	Major assignment: Contribution Paper Final Draft Due Sunday, December 6 by midnight on Canvas